



Social Psychology (SOCPSY)

Module 1: What is Social Psychology

Social Influence and Methods

Lesson Notes

KMVTECHUG

Version: 2026

Social Influence in Daily Life

Social influence is when the real or imagined presence of others changes our thoughts, feelings, or behaviour. Influence is not always harmful. It helps groups coordinate, follow safety rules, and learn from each other. The skill is noticing when influence helps and when it harms judgment.

Campus examples are easy to find. Students speak more quietly in the library because others are studying. A group member may agree with a project idea they privately doubt, in order to keep peace. Dress codes for formal events are followed because they are expected.

How We Study Social Behaviour

Researchers use several methods. Experiments change one factor and measure the effect, which helps test cause and effect. Surveys ask many people about attitudes or experiences and provide breadth. Observation watches behaviour in natural settings. Case analysis takes a deep look at one event or person.

Each method has strengths. Experiments are strong on cause; surveys reach many people; observation captures real-world behaviour. The goal in this course is understanding the idea, not memorising every procedure.

Key Thinkers: A Simple Map

Kurt Lewin argued that behaviour depends on the person and the situation together. Solomon Asch showed how group pressure can lead people to give answers they know are wrong. Stanley Milgram studied obedience to authority. Leon Festinger developed the idea of cognitive dissonance, the discomfort that arises when beliefs and actions conflict.

Treat these names as anchors for later modules. You need to recognise which idea connects to which name when the topic returns.

Reflect: Which of the four names above links most closely to a situation you have seen in a student group, and why?

Closing

Module 1 defined social psychology, explained why it matters on a Ugandan campus, and introduced influence, methods, and key thinkers. Module 2 turns to the social self.